

(The water ripples as hands dip in, cupping the water gently. With the same grace, these hands clasp together and, when they open, what's left is a cat.)

[Press any harder and there is nothing at all.]

At the edges of a snowy forest, a silhouette of a cat sits, yellow eyes blinking to take in the winter ahead. Its tail sways lazily, anxiously, annoyed. The slush surrounds it, turning into puddles, soon to be taken by the sun and turned back into snow. Cold wind bites at its nose, urging it away. The cat takes it as challenge.

And when the cat takes its first steps into the snow, the forest laughs, successfully swallowing up another.

(Welcome.)

[May you never leave.]



The cat does not respond to the mockery of the trees or the cries of the birds. It does not answer to any questions, it does not worry about the trail prints that it does not leave behind.

(Where did they go?)

[Did they ever exist to being with?]

The first time the cat stops is for a bird. It lays still on its side, head pressed against the ground, white feathers nearly blending in with the pale snow. The eyes, though very dead, are very blue. An unblinking and all-seeing sort of blue. Perhaps the only thing that allows the cat to see the bird.

“Are you dead?” The cat asks.

“You tell me. What does it mean to be dead?” The bird asks as response. Sapphire flashes upwards.

“How would I know? I’ve never died.”

(They say cats have nine lives.)

[They say that water remembers.]

“You must’ve,” the bird insists, eyes unblinking. “At least once. Felt it, perhaps. Unable to do anything except nothing at all.”

“Does sleep count? I’ve done lots of that,” the cat says. “When it rains mostly. Very calming.”

“Do you die when it rains?”

And the cat thinks. It sits in the snow, cold but not lonely, even while its talking to a possibly dead, possibly dying, bird. Softly, it hears the beats of a heart. One of them is alive. What a riddle.

So, the cat responds, “the opposite, I think.”

“The opposite?” And there is amusement in the bird’s caw. “How confusing. Do you die when it doesn’t rain, or do you live when it does?”

“Does that matter?”

“Of course,” the bird, dead, dying, still, smiles. It doesn’t elaborate.

The silence is broken as the cat goes in a circle. “Are you dead?”

And the bird echoes “does that matter?”

Following the script, the cat says, “of course,” though it does not smile.



Later, not long after, the cat will walk away, answerless and full of questions, turning back to see nothing but snow. There is not bird with bright blue eyes, there are no riddles left unanswered.

(What does it mean to be dead?)

[It is to turn into nothing.]

The bird has died.

The cat wonders: if a cat has nine lives, then how many does a bird have?

The forest answers: a cat doesn't have nine lives.

There are no paw prints in the snow, no sound that comes from the cat. It continues forward, unwilling to turn back. The snowstorm will hit eventually. And when it does, perhaps there will be nothing of the cat. But there will be the rain. And as long as it rains, something will remember.

Only time will tell.

"You stick out like a stranger in a home."

The cat stops, looking around to find the origin of the voice. There is nothing but white snow around it.

"Up, you cat. Look up."

And so it looks up, finding a small white thing resting on a tree. A butterfly, it seems, or maybe a moth. White wings and a blue body. What an odd little thing.

"Yellow eyes, hm? How strange," the butterfly flutters down, resting on the cat's head. The cat does nothing to stop it, only continuing onward when it lands safely. Its flutters are audible.

"You're not from here. Are you lost?"

"No," the cat says. "Not at all."

"Is that right? You're certain?"

"I wouldn't have said so if otherwise."

Its wings flutter, something like a laugh. "Looking for something then? Something dear?"

The cat stops. It can look up, but it would not see the butterfly. So it looks forward. "Is that sort of theft common in the area?" And it continues walking.

"Oh, most certainly," the butterfly sighs. "The forest has quite a sneaky fox, you see. It takes only the valuable and precious. The wood from a fire, the sand from an hourglass, the insanity from an artist. A greedy thing it is. What did it take from you? Milk? Claws? Whiskers, perhaps?"

“My cloud,” the cat replies.

And there is, somehow, an audible pause from the butterfly. “Pardon?”

“My cloud,” the cat repeats, the same note in its voice. “My rain cloud. The fox took it.”

The butterfly is silent for another moment. Then, “what a steal.”

The cat makes a sound of agreement. “Mm. Right under my nose as well. A rather skilled thief.”

“Is that right? Hmm, how interesting. You can stop here,” and the cat stops. It watches as the white butterfly flies away and settles on a tree that looks identical to where the cat met it. Had it gone in a circle? “Continue on, cat. I wish you the best on your quest. Try not to sell your soul in these woods.”

“It’s a fox, is it not?” The cat asks, confused. “Do foxes eat souls?”

“No,” the butterfly replies. “But I doubt a cat needs a rain cloud. And yet.”

And yet indeed.



It starts to snow. The soft sort of snow, the sort that easily melts the moment it touches something warm. It might as well be rain with how little time it spends as snow. The cat relishes in it, taking joy in winter’s miracles.

The snow sticks to its fur, easily coming off as the cat shakes itself down. The forest cheers, happy with the weather. The wind smiles, snowflakes swirling in circles. And the cat continues onward, in search of a cloud.

(Freeze the rain and get some snow.)

[Any colder and what comes out is ice.]

And the snow grows bold. The sun starts to fall and the cold becomes bitter. Sensing that the night is no time for adventure, the cat steps to the side and finds a place to sleep. Somewhere with a cover, not necessarily warm, but not getting any colder.

It finds a place under some rocks. A tight fit, snug and comfortable. Languidly, it watches the snow fall. There is no sound as it hits the blanket of existing snow. No plop or patter. The unfamiliarity sits heavy.

(Like a stranger in a home.)

[Like a truth in an act.]

“Are you cold?” A voice comes from above, most likely sitting on the rock that the cat is resting under. “This must be your first snowfall.”

It’s a soft voice, gentle and coaxing. The cat is too snug to bother moving. “Are you not cold? You’re sitting in the snow.”

“Not at all,” a lie, the cat knows. The snowfall has turned into a snowstorm and the trees are nearly snapping in half. “Hardly even chilly.”

“It sounds like you’re being pelted with snow.”

“And what does that sound like?” The voice is amused, a soft curl of mischief and mirth in its notes.

“Like nonsense,” the cat says, eyes closing. The harsh snow nearly sounds like rain. “A fool sitting open in the snow.”

“A fool? Me? You don’t really think that, do you?”

“Only fools talk to sleeping cats.”

“Sleeping cats don’t talk.”

And then there is silence.

Then laughter.

“Aha, fine, fine. You win. You win.”

And the cat dreams of rain.



(How to make a friend in five easy steps.)

[One: steal their valuables.]



The snow is the same level as it was the day before. Not higher, not lower. As if the snowstorm had never happened. Similarly, there is no proof that the cat went to sleep. No sun or moon to tell morning from night. Perhaps neither happened. No snowstorm, no sleep, just a lapse in time.

(What does it mean to be dead?)

[Forgotten, worthless or invisible. Pick a poison.]

The cat continues. There is no other choice to the cat, no other option to ponder. Forward, left or right. Just not back.

But what was back if there was no tracks to prove the cat had walked from that direction?

The cat turns around.

And there sits a wolf, head turned, tail in the snow. White fur and blue eyes.

“Are you alone?” the wolf asks.

“You’re here,” the cat replies. “You tell me.”

“I mean a pack. A family. Friends, partners. Do you have any?” And the cat finally understands that look in its eyes. A deep sort of angry. Old, a scab constantly picked at. “Something to return to?”

“I have myself. Is that not enough?” The cat asks.

And the wolf huffs. “They say people can die of loneliness. Perhaps that will be you.”

“Are you scared of dying?” A miserable, lonely death. No one to hold, to cry to, to say pass on parting words.

“No,” the wolf says. “Just disappearing.”

“Then come with,” the cat nods to the direction it was walking in only a moment ago. “You won’t be alone with me.”

“That’s not,” the wolf sighs, huffs, scoffs. “That’s not the same. It’s not that easy. Alone and lonely are not the same.”

“Yet you can beat them in the same fashion, no?” The cat tilts its head.

(What happens to the curious cat?)

[Who knows. There are too many rhymes that come after.]

“That’s too easy,” the wolf stands, shaking its head. “Far too easy.”

And the cat watches, not knowing what to say. It only hopes that the wolf can find something to call family. Perhaps, then, it won’t be so lonely.

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(In between moments, between snowfalls and snowstorms, there is a singular second in which the forest talks. And it asks: what is so special about your rain cloud?)

And the cat replies: well, I guess it’s my heart in a sense.)

[And the forest, impossibly, goes quiet. Presumably out of shock.

Your heart? The forest asks, double checking.

Mm, the cat hums, in a sense.]

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There is laughter in the forest. Not from the trees, or the wind, but all around. Soft patter of paws, a cackling following the sound. Quick, harsh, mocking. The cat stays still, waiting for its next visitor, however mean it may be.

A bush, snowy and not yet withered, rustles, though not from the wind.

“Are you going to come out?” The cat asks. No response. “I’m patient, I promise.”

“Patient? Or proud,” the bush retorts. And out pops a hare. White fur and blue eyes. “Foolish, clearly, to venture this far in.”

“I prefer the word brave,” the cat says, sitting in the snow, waiting for this to be over.

“Brave is one thing, this is another,” the hare sits in front of the cat. “Is this really worth it? For a rain cloud?”

“My rain cloud,” the cat rolls its yellow eyes. “Is it wrong to take back what’s yours? Especially when you have the power to?”

“Do you? Do you have the power?” Blue eyes narrow, just slightly.

It grows colder. Just slightly.

“The fox doesn’t let go of the things it steals. And it doesn’t take well to thieves either,” the hare adds. “Whatever you’re planning, it won’t work.”

“Not even a deal?” The cat tilts its head.

(How to incite interest in the bored in five easy steps.)

[One: defy expectations.]

“A deal? With what?” The hare very nearly scoffs.

“That’s for the fox to know. Not you,” the cat stands, walking past the hare to continue on. But it pauses for a moment, just to turn and say, “unless you’re willing to give yourself up. I hear that the fox is a fan of souls.”

(What happens to the petty cat?)

[Why does no one ask that one?]

And there is laughter once again. From the trees, to the wind, and the hare.

If it were still there.





(The snow smells sweet.)

[The rain smells like home.]



The cat loses time completely. The trees look the same and the snow is clean. Still, it continues on, determined to take back what belongs to it. No one ever said it would be easy and the cat never expected it to be.

Then the trees rustle and the wind picks up. And “if you’re not the fox, then I have very little business with you.”

“Oh? Here I thought you said you were patient.”

And the snow turns blinding. One moment, it’s a never-ending harsh cold that nearly wipes even the most agile and sturdy of their feet. The next, the snow stops falling altogether. Instead, in its place, is a fox.

White fur.

Blue eyes.

(How to make an enemy in five easy steps.)

[One: steal their valuables.]

“Fox,” the cat says with some laze.

“Cat,” the fox says with some mirth. “What a surprise. I didn’t expect to see you.”

“Yes, and animals come in only white and blue,” the cat sits, ready for this conversation.

“Oh, yes, quite a fascinating forest, don’t you think?” The fox walks closer, tail swaying behind it, no paws in its tracks. “I’m sure they were all very excited to see you. We don’t usually have visitors, after all.”

“Mm,” the cat hums, eyes bored as the fox’s tail wraps around the both of them. “I’m not cold.”

“You should be,” sharp teeth makes a sharp smile.

“My rain cloud,” the cat continues, as it always does. “I’m here to take it back.”

“Is that right?” The fox makes a cooing sound. “What to do, what to do. It seems like I don’t want to give it back.”

““Seems’?”

A sharp smile and narrowed eyes. “I’m open to negotiation.”

“There’s very little to negotiate. My rain cloud. Give it.”

“Should I set the price then? I’m also open to that.”

“Fox.”

“I’d say your soul, but that would be rather boring at this point, no? But I’m open to keeping it. I wonder how that would work. Hmm, I suppose some blood should tie you to the forest for a while. Yes, I wouldn’t mind that.”

“Fox.”

“Or maybe your eyes,” the fox pulls the cat closer until they’re nose to nose. “They’re a very pretty shade of yellow. Better than any sort of stone or leaf that you could find in this dreary place. Or perhaps—”

The cat bites the fox’s face.

“—ow.”

(This wasn’t supposed to happen.)

[What happens to the petty cat?]

A moment passes. Then, “are you not going to let go?” The fox asks, somewhat pained and probably bleeding.

“No,” the cat replies, though muffled with a mouth full of fox and fox blood. Sharp teeth for intimidation versus sharp teeth for survival. “Give me back my rain cloud.” Again, muffled.

“You need to let of me eventually.”

“I’m patient,” muffled with fox once more.

“That wasn’t the case a moment ago,” the fox argues. When the cat doesn’t reply, it sighs. Something deep and heavy. “I’m going to have to drag you with me, aren’t I?”

The cat nods, bringing only more pain to the fox. The cat knows this, of course.

“Don’t grin, I can feel it in my face,” the fox complains, grumbling as it drags the cat back to it’s collection.

(What’s happening?)

[What happens to the petty and tired cat?]

The collection is a little smaller than one would expect. Shiny rocks, pretty flowers. Small, precious things. In the middle of it is a grey, shiny rock. It’s lumpy in shape, almost like a cloud. The cat dislodges itself from the foxes face and picks up the rock with its mouth.

There is a clap of thunder. And snow turns to rain.

The fox looks up, then at the cat. There is exasperation in its blue eyes. “Really?”

All it gets in response is a tail to the face.

And, with cloud in its possession again, the cat walks out of the forest.

The snow melts in the rain.



(With numb hands, the snow is scooped up and packed together. Soon, or perhaps much later, those same hands reveal a fox.)

A human with white hair and bright blue eyes enters a village. It charms people with a sweet smile and kind words. It asks about a cat to those who are willing to listen. It asks about the rain and any clouds that look odd or off. More often than not, it gets odd looks and sideways smiles. But it continues on.

(Goodbye.)

[See you again.]



“A cat?” The man asks, somewhat baffled by the looks of it.

“Yes,” the fox-turned-human, or human-turned-fox, replies. A smile on its face, full of amusement and joy. An odd look for someone looking for their cat. “A nimble little thing. Black fur, yellow eyes. Carries a grey rock in its mouth nearly all the time.”

“Hm, I don’t think so,” the man says. “There aren’t many cats in the area. Or, at the very least, none who are dumb enough to venture inside the village.”

Reasonable, the fox supposes. It is talking to a hunter, after all. Crossbow on his back and all that.

“Shame,” the fox says, not really sad at all. “How about rain? Any rain clouds that’s passed by?”

And, fortunately, this question usually has a response. “Oh, yes. About a week ago. Um, though I can’t say I’m certain about... the clouds.”

“That’s perfectly alright,” an incredibly mediocre amount of information, but fine. “Thank you so much. Good luck with the hunt. I hope you get a fox or two. I think I saw some with white fur out there.”

“Really? Well, that would be quite the sell,” the hunter laughs, eyes going up to the fox-turned-human’s hair. “Would go for a lot.”

“So do pretty ladies,” the fox gives one last look at the man, smiling with sharp teeth as his eyes go wide. “Go check on your wife, yeah?”

It laughs at the sound of cursing and panic. But the fox is already no where to be seen, lost in a dozen veils of illusions and tricks.

“Mr’ow.”

The fox looks down to see a cat by its feet. Tabby, green eyes.

“Oh, don’t give me that. He would’ve absolutely kidnapped me if I stayed any longer. Or worse, he would’ve called me a witch!” The fox complains, even while it bends down to pick up the cat and carries it in its arms.

(The fox has gone insane.)

[There’s no saving this anymore. Everyone, wrap it up!]

“Mr’ow,” the cat, this stranger cat that doesn’t care one bit for the rain, says, deadpan.

“I know, it’s ridiculous. I’m much worse than any ‘witch’ out there,” the fox sighs. “How does that blasted cat travel so quickly? I know I gave it a head start, but really. I’m sure the rain has to stay for some time before it leaves.”

“Maow,” the stranger cat jumps out of the fox’s arms, turning its head to blink at the fox before leaving.

“Ah, how sad,” the fox smiles. “Am I really so unlikeable?”

(Yes.)

[Absolutely.]



The next village is a little easier, a little more damp.

“I can’t say I saw this cat of yours,” the woman says. “But it did rain about three days ago. The cloud went east.”

“Should I be curious about why you payed attention to the direction of the cloud’s journey?” The fox asks, endlessly amused.

“Hah, ‘cloud’s journey’. What a nice way to put it,” she smiles, looking that fox in its eyes. “And you were the one to ask, weren’t you? Don’t start sounding ungrateful.”

The fox raises its hands in surrender. “I wouldn’t dream of it, Ma’am.”

(Shameless.)

[Tricky thing.]



It's raining. The human, fox, whatever, holds an umbrella in its hand. Look a little closer and perhaps the keener eye would realise it's made of ice.

The fox walks through the streets, ignoring the stares of the other people. The fox looks high and low, trying to find a cozy nook that's coincidentally cat shaped.

It takes an hour or so, but it finds the right place.

"Mr'ow," the fox says.

The cat, the one with yellow eyes and black fur, turns to the fox, raising it's head out from underneath the shade.

"Fox."

"Cat," the fox smiles, waving away its umbrella into snow.

"That was fast," the cat yawns, sharp teeth glinting in the dim light. "Too fast. Did you chase me right after I left?"

"I gave you a full ten minute head start," the fox leans down, kneeling next to the cat. It doesn't pet the cat though. The fox is rather fond of its hands. "Though, I suppose I was a little more motivated with my forest turned to mush."

Quickly, faster than the cat could think, a hand snatches the rock from the cat. The wind blows with triumph. Winter comes early this year.

"Apologies," the fox says when the cat tries to scratch at it and fails. The fox stands, stretching out its legs. "I'll think of something more creative. How does that sound?"

(Are they flirting???)

[...yes.]

The cat stretches out its limbs as the rain comes to a stop. Yellow eyes meet blue. "You better."

And the fox steals the heart of the cat once more.

((Congratulations. You've read 14 pages of nothing. Thank you for sticking around.))